Over-the-top (OTT) platforms: a review, synthesis and research directions

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Abstract

Purpose – In this era of technological advancement, the capabilities of devices and telecommunications have changed the pattern of media consumption among consumers. This study examined the research landscape and advancements in OTT services.

Design/methodology/approach – This study adopted a hybrid review consisting of bibliometric and thematic analyses to present advancements in the OTT platforms. A hybrid review integrates both systematic and narrative approaches by emphasizing a literature search strategy and the study selection process.

Findings – This study focuses on previous literature to understand recent developments in the domain. The authors derive six major OTT themes: OTT infrastructure and technology advancement, OTT consumption behaviour, shifting trends towards OTT platforms, viewers' engagement in digital media, OTT in the global market, OTT policies and regulatory mechanisms.

Practical implications – The findings of this study will be useful for marketers/stakeholders associated with the entertainment and media industries, such as sales promotion teams, media planners/advertisers, content management companies and policy regulators, to penetrate OTT viewers.

Originality/value – The literature related to OTT is progressively rising, but it remains highly fragmented because of inconsistencies in the methodologies and theories used in the domain of OTT. This study offers directions in terms of theory, methodology and future research on OTT services.

Keywords Digital media consumption, OTT platforms, Streaming services, Literature review, Thematic analysis

Paper type Literature review

1. Introduction

Connectivity has created a diverse manifold of globalization. The term over-the-top (OTT), refers to the "video-on-demand" platforms, and has expanded phenomenally on a global scale over the past few years (Mulla, 2022; Sharma and Lulandala, 2023). OTT is a process that has evaded conventional channels of media content such as cables, television, and big screens, and is concerned with streaming media content related to entertainment (Chen *et al.*, 2017), including web series, movies, reality shows, and serials. The availability of affordable internet data connections, easy accessibility of smart devices, technological innovations, and improved networks have led to the emergence of OTT platforms (Lee *et al.*, 2020; Kwak *et al.*, 2021). OTT content has become the latest standalone digital multimedia platform, where

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viewers are completely independent in choosing their preferred media content (Puthiyakath and Goswami, 2021).

Statista (2023) stated that the number of OTT video users was 3.26 billion by 2022, increasing to 3.51 billion by 2023, which is expected to reach 4.22 billion users by 2027.The market for OTT platforms is estimated to grow at a rate of 10.01% per year (CAGR 2023–2027), with a projected market size of $462.90bn by 2027. McKinsey (2010) and Deloitte (2015) reported that OTT services have captivated proponents by exerting a powerful impact and gaining momentum because of their promising future, which indicates that OTT services will influence traditional television and media consumption among viewers. In today's technological world, the availability of smart devices has transformed digital media consumption among users (Flayelle *et al.*, 2017; Dwivedi *et al.*, 2021; Sadana and Sharma, 2021; Walsh and Singh, 2021), providing an opportunity for the digital media industry, marketers, and business scholars to explore new avenues (Modgil *et al.*, 2022). OTT media content has become popular in the present era and is supported by technology-enabled environments (Kraus *et al.*, 2022).

Previous studies in the field of media and entertainment have explored viewers' preferences for media choices, entertainment spending patterns (Kim *et al.*, 2016; Shin *et al.*, 2016; Chen *et al.*, 2017; Hutchins *et al.*, 2019; Shin and Park, 2021; Walsh and Singh, 2021), preference for new and original content among the new generation (Sadana and Sharma, 2021), and OTT consumption pre and post COVID-19 (Sharma and Lulandala, 2023).

The shift from conventional media to OTT services, especially during COVID-19 (Sharma and Lulandala, 2023), has created tough competition among media service providers to attract and retain viewers. According to Walsh and Singh (2021) the concept of "Cord Cutting" has emerged, where viewers cancel their cable or satellite subscriptions for multichannel television services and instead access media content at their convenience with an internet connection.

OTT platforms offer marketing professionals new approaches to enhance sales revenue and refine marketing strategies by leveraging artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning (ML), as highlighted by Akter *et al.* (2022). Despite being in the early stages of development, these technologies hold promising potential for optimizing content promotion and new marketing models for media/content planners, for advertisers such as geo-targeting (Lian *et al.*, 2019) to customize their advertisements for local audiences, and integrating region-specific messaging, promotions, or events.

Previous studies related to OTT discussed adoption (Mulla, 2022), convenience (Shin *et al.*, 2016), preference (Shin and Park, 2021), consumption (Walsh and Singh, 2021), and quality of service (Koenuma *et al.*, 2017). However, these studies do not provide a comprehensive synthesis of the literature in terms of theories and methods. Although Mulla (2022) published a review on OTT services, the study was limited to factors that influence users' attitudes toward OTT media adoption and lacks theoretical and methodological advances. For instance, Singh *et al.* (2022) attempted bibliometric analyses of OTT literature, but their study was limited to the identification of themes, excluding more recent OTT service advances.

The literature surrounding OTT services is growing rapidly and necessitates further exploration by researchers to advance theoretical perspectives. By conducting a hybrid review, that combines bibliometric and thematic analysis, we can examine existing research, identify emerging trends, and determine future research directions in this domain. This study has two objectives: *First,* it attempts to assess the development of OTT research trends over time. The *second* objective was to discover gaps and propose future directions for OTT research.

Literature reviews (LR) serve as valuable tools for evaluating current knowledge, identifying gaps, and proposing new research directions which can be leveraged for synthesis and assessment of existing research work in a systematic manner (Agarwal *et al.*, 2024; Swain *et al.*, 2023a; Kumar *et al.*, 2023; Jebarajakirthy *et al.*, 2021; Bodolica and Spraggon, 2018). In the current research work, LR approach has been used for synthesis and assessment in the domain of OTT Research. The outcome of this study will be useful for stakeholders involved in offering OTT services, such as media content service providers, sales promotion teams/advertisers, and policy regulators.

OTT services allow *advertisers* to create personalized and targeted advertising in order to engage with their specific target audience, by utilizing techniques such as geo-targeting and geo-fencing which allow advertisers to customize their messages, thereby enhancing user interaction to optimizing ads performance (Lian *et al.*, 2019; Shin and Park, 2021).*Content providers* can create meaningful connections tailored to particular demographics, employing region-specific targeting methods, to cater a niche segment that prefer communication in regional languages which give wider coverage to the viewers (Susanno *et al.*, 2019). It is imperative for *regulators/government* bodies to evaluate content that may involve obscenity, defamation and violation of religious and social sentiments to effectively enforce industry compliances. Moreover, regulators possess the capacity to establish a framework addressing issues related to intellectual property rights, consumer privacy, and security through the incorporation of blockchain technology (Chen *et al.*, 2018).

The finding of the study has both theoretical and practical significance. Theoretically, we synthesized the OTT literature with respect to the examined theories and methods used by the scholars by adopting a hybrid review approach. We also identified several research gaps and suggested future research directions to advance the existing literature in this domain by identifying research themes. Practically, our review offers an opportunity for OTT service providers to explore new insights to establish marketing strategies to engage and offer customized services for the viewers.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. In the second section, we present a literature review on OTT platforms. In section third, we present the methodology and search strategy. Section four summarizes the results. Section five and six discussed the theoretical and practical implications of this study. Finally, we conclude this study with the following recommendations and limitations.

2. Review of literature

2.1 Change in media consumption behaviour

Since the inception of technological advancements, the inclination to watch television has changed significantly, viewers rely heavily on digital content in the technological world which resulting in a shift from traditional to OTT media platforms (Castro *et al.*, 2019; Braun, 2013). Moreover, with the advent of OTT services, viewers can enjoy broadcast content using smartphones, tablets, and computers wherever and whenever they want (Shin *et al.*, 2016) which have transformed viewers thought process, communication, and internet usage by offering a diverse array of content (Brown, 2014).

Online and electronic media are becoming increasingly popular due to affordable internet access and prices, promoting viewers' sense of connectedness (Braun, 2013; Lu *et al.*, 2021). The satisfaction and acceptance of OTT media among viewers is increased by the quality and the freedom to access the content (Kim *et al.*, 2016; Lu *et al.*, 2021; Koenuma *et al.*, 2017). OTT viewers value features such as portability and high-quality services that allow them to access content in their preferred language and time, which motivates viewers to use OTT services more habitually (Flayelle *et al.*, 2017; Susanno *et al.*, 2019).

Lee *et al.* (2020) underlined that OTT acceptance among viewers is due to customized content, features, quality, affordable pricing, and preferences. Kwak *et al.* (2021) pointed out that OTT streaming services provide differentiated and high-quality content across a variety of devices, providing ease of use for viewers. With the advent of the COVID-19 pandemic, there has been a change in the behaviour and lifestyle of the common masses (Iivari *et al.*, 2020), restrictions to move outside the home, isolation of people, and adherence to social distancing norms during the COVID-19 pandemic (Sehgal *et al.*, 2021; Khanna *et al.*, 2023) have increased digital media consumption, thus creating a huge demand for OTT platforms (Modgil *et al.*, 2022).

According to Shin *et al.* (2016), not only streaming service providers were entering the OTT service market, but internet service providers were also vying for market dominance. Oyedele and Simpson (2018) states that to maintain a competitive edge, OTT providers should emphasize the diverse range of viewing options they offer and develop strategies to cater to viewer preferences. OTT service providers should deliver user-friendly and personalized content (Oyedele and Simpson, 2018) based on viewers' preferences. The growing popularity of OTT platforms has led to a significant shift in viewership from traditional TV to OTT, demonstrating the superiority of OTT media in terms of competitive advantage (Chen *et al.*, 2018).

2.2 The changing landscapes of OTT trends

Following Yun *et al.* (2019), we utilized word-cloud analysis to depict time-based trends and commonly employed keywords in OTT research. This analysis was conducted based on the distribution of articles over the years. We pasted abstracts of papers from each yearly interval into WordClouds.com, an online word cloud analysis tool. This study was conducted on the basis of the distribution of articles by year. The results of the analysis depicted in Figure 1 indicate that network distribution and broadcasting were the primary areas of interest for OTT research between 2012 and 2014. In subsequent years (i.e. 2015–2017), the terms "consumers," "network," and "service providers" service providers emerged. It was followed by "content," "services," "satisfaction," and "experiences" during 2018–2020 and 2021–2023, commonly accompanied by "traditional," "global," "consumption," and "media."

According to the word cloud analysis, "OTT," "content," "services," and "media" are among the most often used keywords in all four time periods. This demonstrates that OTT researchers continued to be interested in the area of user experience and satisfaction provided by the platforms, even though the majority of the literature was shifting toward cross-border content.

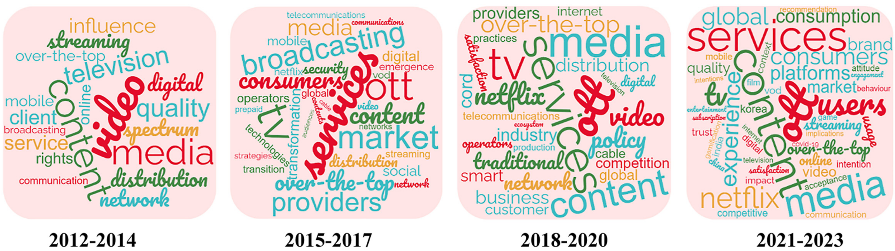


Figure 1. Chronological trends in OTT research

Source(s): Authors' compilation

3. Methodology

3.1 Review of structure

To synthesize existing OTT research, the current study combines bibliometric techniques and a methodological literature review using the PRISMA framework (Swain *et al.*, 2023a). Structural and bibliometric reviews can be used in an integrative literature review (Paul and Criado, 2020). A structured review offers a thorough synthesis (Tranfield *et al.*, 2003) of the available research with respect to the theory, methodology, and variables used in the study (Swain *et al.*, 2023b), highlighting future research opportunities by identifying research gaps in the field (Corbet *et al.*, 2019). Bibliometric reviews examine literature based on journals of publication, publication year, and country (Paul *et al.*, 2021). Thus, through the integration of structural and bibliometric review methodologies, this integrative review offers a meticulous framework for synthesizing the over-the-top literature.

3.2 Search strategy

3.2.1 Keywords selection. As per the search recommendation of Talwar *et al.* (2020), we started by searching for papers on Google Scholar that contained the term “OTT platforms”. We then examined the first 25 publications to update the keyword lists. It was found that “OTT [1]” “over the top,” “OTT platforms”, “OTT services” “OTT and streaming” and “over the top and services, were the regularly utilized keywords either in the title, abstract, or keyword list. Therefore, we used these keywords to find appropriate papers published in other scholarly databases.

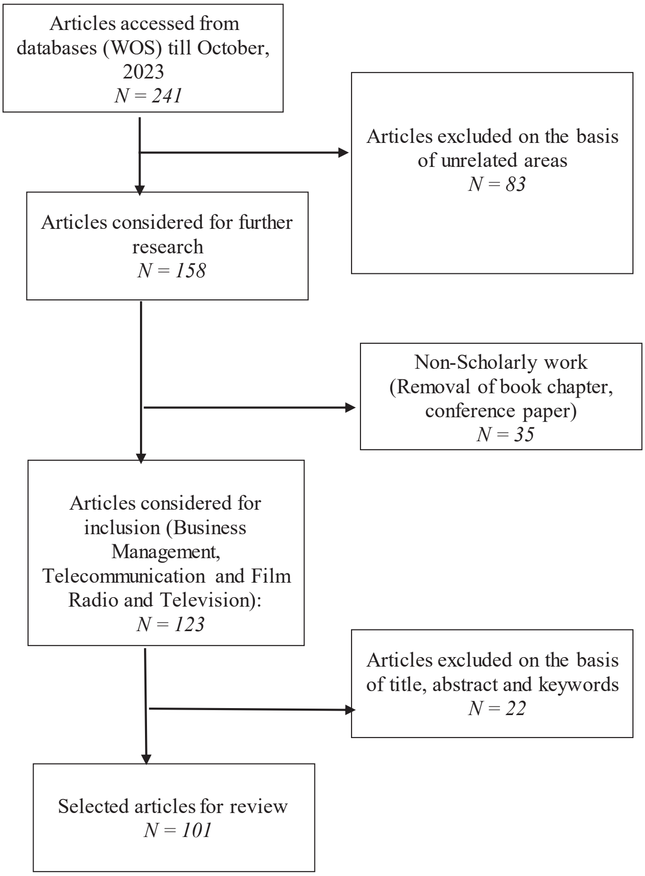
3.2.2 Database selection and article. Articles published in the Web of Science (WOS) database, known for their quality indexing of research publications, were utilized to extract relevant documents (Johnsen *et al.*, 2017; Burki *et al.*, 2022) from its inception until October 2023. The authors extracted data from the available sources using the keywords mentioned above.

3.3 Journal selection and eligibility criteria

3.3.1 Inclusion and exclusion. We obtained 241 research papers (Figure 2) found in online databases using the search string mentioned in footnote 1. Next, we reduced the number of publications for our study by using the inclusion and exclusion criteria. Consequently, 83 of the 241 articles were excluded because they were not published in the fields of business management, telecommunication, film, or television; thus, 158 papers remained in our database. Next, the remaining 35 articles were not deemed to be scholarly works (e.g. book chapters, conferences) and were thus removed from our database, leaving 123 papers. We also used the title and abstract of the remaining articles as additional criteria (Johnsen *et al.*, 2017) to locate papers published in business management journals. Consequently, 22 additional studies were excluded, leaving 101 high-quality studies. Hence, 101 research papers published in 66 academic publications between 2012 and 2023 were compiled in the current review.

3.4 Research design and data collection

Table 1 shows that the maximum number of papers (33 out of 101) adopted a survey-based design, whereas 30 studies adopted a qualitative method. Other studies employed experimental (16 papers) and conceptual approaches (six papers). However, we did not find any systematic review on OTT, which justifies the need for SLR in this domain. Furthermore, 24 survey-based studies employed the online method for data collection, five survey-based studies employed the offline method, and five survey-based studies employed a combination of online and offline data collection. Online data collection is preferred and made



Source(s): Authors' compilation

Figure 2.
Inclusion and Exclusion using PRISMA flow diagram

possible because OTT revolves around digital infrastructure and connectivity. Few studies have employed case study research (five studies), empirical (four), quantitative (four), content analysis (one), or mixed methods (one). Researchers prefer a general consumer sample because real consumers are beneficiaries of OTT services.

3.5 Theoretical perspectives of OTT platforms research

The articles were also analysed in terms of their theoretical underpinnings. Table 2 lists the theories discussed and used in the OTT platform literature and shows that the User Gratifications Theory (UGT) (Chen, 2019a; Sadana and Sharma, 2021; Meng and Leung, 2021; Kim and Lee, 2023), Technology Acceptance Models (TAM) (Iyer and Siddhartha, 2021; Sharma and Kakkar, 2022; Ogbo *et al.*, 2020), Diffusion of Innovation Theory (Li, 2020; Jeong *et al.*, 2022), and Random Utility Theory (Shin *et al.*, 2016; Kim *et al.*, 2017), have been used in several studies. A few other theoretical frameworks, such as Expectancy Value Theory (Shin and Park, 2021), Platform Theory (Kour and Chhabria, 2022), Value-Based Theory (Yoon and Kim, 2023), Dual Process Theory (Shin *et al.*, 2022), Evolutionary Game Theory (Wang, 2020), Prospect Theory (Chen *et al.*, 2017), Media Complementary Theory (Fuduric *et al.*, 2020),

Research methods	No. of studies	Supporting literature
Survey		
Online + Offline (Hybrid)	4	Abreu *et al.* (2017), Governo *et al.* (2017), Jang *et al.* (2023), Jain (2021)
Online	24	Soren and Chakraborty (2023), Kim *et al.* (2017), Jeong *et al.* (2022), Chakraborty *et al.* (2023), Shin and Park (2021), Yoon and Kim (2023), Kwon *et al.* (2021), Bhattacharyya *et al.* (2022), Koul *et al.* (2021); Kwak *et al.* (2021), Puthiyakath and Goswami (2021), Sadana and Sharma (2021), Lim and Kim (2023), Prasad (2022), Nata *et al.* (2022), Quang and Thuy (2023), Prince and Greenstein (2016), Amoroso *et al.* (2021), Chen (2019a), Sharma and Kakkar (2022), Meng and Leung (2021), Levine *et al.* (2021), Nagaraj *et al.* (2021), Shin *et al.* (2016)
Offline	5	Iyer and Siddhartha (2021), Chen and Liu (2019), Shin and Shim (2017), Yu *et al.* (2016)
Experiment	16	Ogbo *et al.* (2020), Kim and Lee (2023), Lu *et al.* (2021), Seo and Park (2021), Shin *et al.* (2022), Gupta and Singharia (2021), Park (2019), Claeys (2014), Vallett *et al.* (2013), Wolf and Donato (2019), Ribke (2021), Ham and Lee (2020), Lee and Kim (2017), Goebert *et al.* (2022), Morais *et al.* (2022), Barroso *et al.* (2012)
Conceptual	6	Arslan and Tetik (2021), Park (2018), Jung and Melguizo (2023), Wang (2020), Papanis *et al.* (2014), Hutchins *et al.* (2019)
Qualitative (Interview)	31	Sharma *et al.* (2023), Sharma and Lulandala (2023), Kour and Chhabria (2022), Flensburg (2021), Fuduric *et al.* (2020), Stork *et al.* (2017), Dwyer *et al.* (2018), Lee *et al.* (2020), Baladron and Rivero (2019), Jang *et al.* (2021), Nam *et al.* (2023), Valdez-De-Leon (2016), Li (2020), Kim *et al.* (2021), Jayakar and Park (2020), Dagnino (2018), Tickell and Evens (2021), Wang and Sun (2021), Barra (2020), Wayne and Castro (2021), Pajkovic (2022), Radosinska (2017), Zhao (2017), Sar (2023), Allam and Olmsted (2021), Braun (2013), Esler (2016), Modgil *et al.* (2022), Li *et al.* (2023), Shim and Shin (2019), Kim (2022) Wang and Jung (2022)
Others (Content analysis)	1	Ramasoota and Kitikamdhron (2021)
Empirical	4	Kwak *et al.* (2021), Shim *et al.* (2022), Tan (2021), Neira *et al.* (2021)
Quantitative	4	Fuduric *et al.* (2018), Moyano *et al.* (2019), Silva and Lima (2022), Sanchez *et al.* (2021)
Mixed Method	1	Roig *et al.* (2021)
Case study research	5	Flew (2014), Meese (2020), Steemers (2016), Iordache (2022), Kostovska *et al.* (2020)

Source(s): Authors' compilation

Table 1. Research methods used in OTT research

Media Displacement Theory (Fuduric *et al.*, 2020) Interest-Driven Creator Theory (Soren and Chakraborty, 2023) and Means-End Chain Theory (Sharma *et al.*, 2023), Theory of Consumption Values (Chakraborty *et al.*, 2023), Unified Theory of Acceptance on Use of Technology-UTAUT2 (Bhattacharyya *et al.*, 2022), Psychological Ownership Theory (Seo and Park, 2021), Niche Theory (Puthiyakath and Goswami (2021), Market Segmentation Theory (Shim *et al.*, 2022), Experience Economy Theory (Nata *et al.*, 2022), Justice Theory (Quang and Thuy, 2023), Truth-Default Theory (Levine *et al.*, 2021), and Actor-Network Theory (Shim and Shin, 2019) have also been discussed.

Interestingly, although researchers have investigated OTT platforms since 2012, only a few theories have been applied to underpin research in this domain. Only a small percentage of the studies have incorporated a theoretical framework. While analysing the papers

Theories used in OTT research	Articles	Authors
Uses and Gratifications Theory	4	Chen (2019a) Sadana and Sharma (2021) Meng and Leung (2021) Kim and Lee (2023)
Technology Acceptance Model	3	Iyer and Siddhartha (2021) Sharma and Kakkar (2022) Ogbo *et al.* (2020)
Diffusion of Innovation Theory	2	Jeong *et al.* (2022) Li (2020)
Random Utility Theory	2	Kim *et al.* (2017) Shin *et al.* (2016)
Expectancy Value Theory	1	Shin and Park (2021)
Platform Theory	1	Kour and Chhabria (2022)
Value-Based Theory	1	Yoon and Kim (2023)
Dual Process Theory	1	Shin *et al.* (2022)
Evolutionary Game Theory	1	Wang (2020)
Prospect Theory	1	Chen and Liu (2017)
Media Complementary Theory	1	Fuduric *et al.* (2020)
Media Displacement Theory	1	Fuduric *et al.* (2020)
Interest –Driven Creator Theory	1	Soren and Chakraborty (2023)
Means-End Chain Theory	1	Sharma *et al.* (2023)
Theory of Consumption Values (TCV)	1	Chakraborty *et al.* (2023)
Unified Theory of Acceptance on Use of Technology (UTAUT2)	1	Bhattacharyya *et al.* (2022)
Psychological Ownership Theory (POT)	1	Seo and Park (2021)
Niche Theory	1	Puthiyakath and Goswami (2021)
Market Segmentation Theory	1	Shim *et al.* (2022)
Experience Economy Theory	1	Nata *et al.* (2022)
Justice Theory	1	Quang and Thuy (2023)
Truth-Default Theory	1	Levine *et al.* (2021)
Actor-Network Theory	1	Shim and Shin (2019)

Source(s): Authors' compilation

Table 2.
Theories used in OTT research

considered in the current study, only 23 papers were found to employ a theoretical framework, enhancing the strength of their findings by validating them through the application of a theoretical model. The OTT domain lacks concentrated attention on a specific set of theories. The literature is characterized by diverse theoretical perspectives and determining factors, and previous studies have not had a solid theoretical foundation. The absence of extensive reliance on a specific set of theories highlights the potential for further theoretical exploration in OTT research.

Despite the available literature on OTT, there is a lack of clarity regarding the development of research in this domain. Therefore, synthesizing the existing research studies employed in OTT services will facilitate an understanding of the domain's evolution and current status while also highlighting the gaps in existing research to guide future investigations in this area. The theories used for OTT platform research are listed in Table 2.

3.5.1 Uses and gratification theory. The uses and gratifications theory (UGT), first proposed by Katz and Lazerfield in 1955, is a widely adopted theory for explaining why people consume media. The UGT examines how individuals actively look for media and content to fulfil specific needs and desires (Sahu *et al.*, 2021). This theory explores the daily media consumption pattern of individuals (Ruggiero, 2018), emphasizing that people are aware of their own needs and intentionally choose media services depending on their choice (Chen, 2019a). It posits that media consumption is a deliberate and goal-oriented activity.

With this theory, the emphasis is shifted from how media affects audiences to how audiences use media to satisfy their needs (Sadana and Sharma, 2021). The theory is applied to OTT services, as it focuses on the requirements, motivations, and satisfaction of media users (Sadana and Sharma, 2021). UGT is built on two key assumptions about media users. First, it posits that media users actively choose the content they consume, rather than being passive users of media. Second, users are aware of the reasons behind their media choices and select the media that best aligns with their needs and desires.

3.5.2 Technology acceptance model (TAM). The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) introduced by Davis (1989) predicts users' behaviour toward the acceptance, adoption, and usage of technology. TAM posits two primary constructs–perceived ease of use (PEOU) and perceived usefulness (PU)to investigate the impact of technology on user behaviour (Davis, 1989). TAM contends that when viewers are exposed to a new technology, various factors play a role in how and when they choose to utilize it. Viewers' perceived ease of use (PEOU) and perceived usefulness (PU) of online subscriptions were enhanced by permission-seeking emails, which in turn increased their consumption. PU can be defined as a user's belief in adopting OTT services (Camilleri and Falzon, 2021). PEOU is a term used to describe how much effort an individual spends on learning the use of technology. In this study, PEOU was used to describe user perceptions of convenience and satisfaction in terms of ease. The desire to utilize video-on-demand services is significantly and favourably affected by PEOU, PU, perceived enjoyment, and content. This suggests that users are more open to adopting emerging technologies owing to their utility and ease of use. TAM has been broadly applied in studies on technology adoption (Camilleri and Falzon, 2021; Shah and Mehta, 2022). Hence, TAM influences the acceptance of OTT services.

3.5.3 Diffusion of Innovation Theory. People value technology for its functionalities and social benefits, as per Rogers' perspective. When people embrace technology primarily for its social benefits, lifestyle also plays a significant role in adoption behaviour (Chan and Leung, 2005). Marketing researchers frequently use lifestyle to forecast consumption patterns (Wei, 2006), which helps researchers in understanding the psychological preferences of their target audience (Leung and Chen, 2017).

This model posits that the acceptance of technology, as proposed by Rogers (2003), is contingent upon its alignment with users' needs and preferences. Rogers introduced the concept of technology innovation, wherein the tendency of consumers to adopt technologies is influenced by their prior experiences. Thus, by analysing patterns of technology innovation, researchers can effectively forecast the adoption of new technologies.

3.5.4 Random Utility Theory. In Random Utility Theory (RUT) individuals are assumed to make choices based on the utility they derive from each option (Baltas and Doyle, 2001). In the context of OTT services, the utility function may include factors such as content quality, price, ease of use, variety of content, and platform features. RUT posits that choices are probabilistic and that individuals choose the option that maximizes their expected utility (Shin *et al.*, 2016). However, randomness is also involved in decision-making. Thus, while users might have a preference for a particular OTT service based on its features and content, there is still a probability associated with choosing other services owing to random factors (Kim *et al.*, 2017). By analysing the utility functions of different consumer segments (based on demographics, preferences, etc.), service providers can predict which OTT services are likely to be more popular and attract more subscribers. Service providers with broader appeal can capture more market share. By analysing how price adjustments impact the utility function and demand for OTT services, providers can determine optimal pricing strategies to increase revenue or market penetration. (Shin *et al.*, 2016). For example, users who find a service highly useful may be less price sensitive and more likely to remain subscribed if service providers offer tailored content.

4. Result and discussion

The trend of publications from 2012 to 2023 shows that the number of publications increased from 1 to 9 from 2012 to 2017 (See Figure 3). Further, the number of publications increased from nine to 31 from 2017 to 2021. Figure 2 shows the increase in the number of publications over the past 12 years. This indicates that OTT has emerged in the last few years.

4.1 Geographical distribution of the articles

The current study revealed that 20 countries have contributed to the domain of OTT research, indicating that this area is still in its nascent stage. The top five countries that have published the highest number of publications on OTT are South Korea, the USA, India, China, and Canada. It can be observed that the Asian continent dominates in the publication of OTT research. Published articles show that these countries have focused their research on OTT services adoption and usage. They have adopted adequate practices for viewers' consumption patterns, investment in infrastructure, and technological advancement. This has resulted in increased demand for OTT platforms in recent years.

4.2 Bibliographic coupling

Multiple common references among two or more publications indicate a deeper relationship in the subject matter addressed in such studies (Donthu *et al.*, 2021). The unit of analysis for coupling was articles/documents. In this study, we undertook a default threshold of five citations for each document and subsequently obtained 43 relevant documents out of 101. Furthermore, out of these 101 documents, only 43 consisted of a large set; hence, only they were used for bibliographic coupling analysis. From this large set of 43 documents, we obtained six themes/clusters (See Figure 4) for network visualization. As an acceptable practice, the top ten cited articles under each theme/cluster were identified, as shown in Table 3.

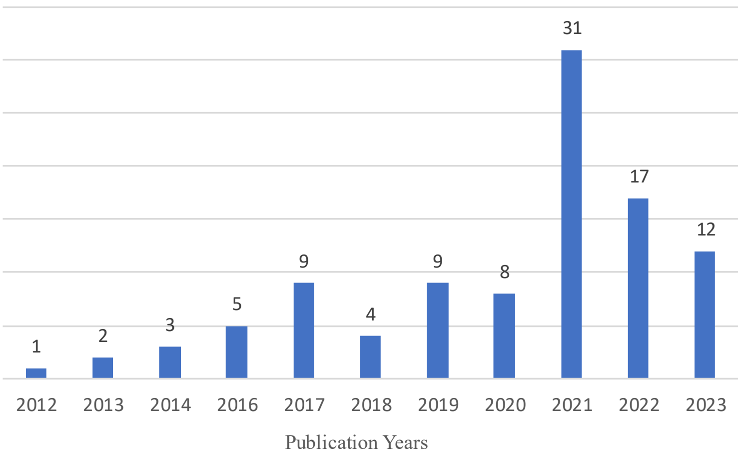


Figure 3. Year-wise publications

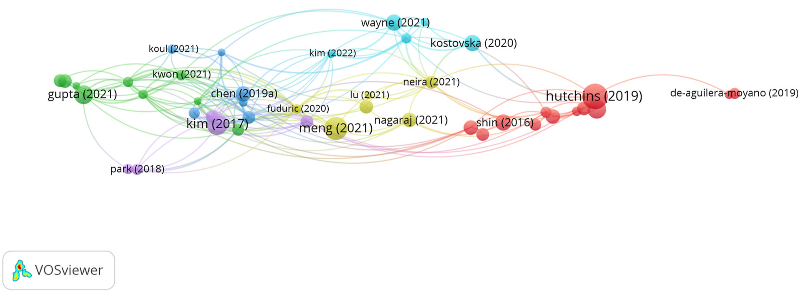
Source(s): Authors' compilation

4.3 Discussion

Based on a bibliographic coupling analysis, six clusters were identified for the OTT platforms. Next, we analysed each cluster to understand the area of research focus.

Cluster 1: OTT infrastructure and technology advancement

The evolution of OTT infrastructure and technology is marked by the relentless pursuit of seamless streaming experiences. Innovations in content delivery networks (Lee *et al.*, 2020) have enhanced the robustness of OTT platforms among viewers (Shin *et al.*, 2016; Li, 2020). Internet-connected technology and multiple screens have allowed access to portals such as digital media players and "smart" televisions (Hutchins *et al.*, 2019). Furthermore, the integration of cloud-based solutions has revolutionized scalability and flexibility, allowing efficient resource utilization. To conduct a thorough analysis of the current state of the digital media sector, Kwak *et al.* (2021) emphasized the competition between internet service



Source(s): Authors' compilation using VOS-viewer

Figure 4. Network visualization for bibliographic coupling analysis

No	Theme	Contributed articles of each theme	No. of articles
1	OTT infrastructure and technology development	Abreu *et al.* (2017), Baladron and Rivero (2019), Braun (2013), Moyano *et al.* (2019), Hutchins *et al.* (2019), Prince and Greenstein (2016), Radosinska (2017), Shim and Shin (2019), Shin and Shim (2017), Esler (2016), Yu *et al.* (2016), Zhao (2017)	12
2	OTT consumption behavior	Amoroso *et al.* (2021), Bhattacharyya *et al.* (2022), Chakraborty *et al.* (2023), Chen (2019a), Gupta and Singharia (2021), Kwak *et al.* (2021), Kwon *et al.* (2021), Li (2020)	9
3	Transitioning toward the OTT platform	Chen (2019b), Sanchez *et al.* (2021), Koul *et al.* (2021), Puthiyakath and Goswami (2021), Sadana and Sharma (2021), Shin and Park (2021)	6
4	Consumer engagement in modern media	Fuduric *et al.* (2020), Lu *et al.* (2021), Meng and Leung (2021), Nagaraj *et al.* (2021), Neira *et al.* (2021), Pajkovic (2022)	6
5	OTT in the global market	Dwyer *et al.* (2018), Fuduric *et al.* (2018), Kim *et al.* (2017), Park (2018, 2019)	5
6	OTT Policies and Regulatory Mechanisms	Iordache (2022), Kim (2022), Kostovska *et al.* (2020), Ramasoota and Kitikamdhron (2021), Wayne and Castro (2021)	5

Source(s): Authors' compilation

Table 3. Contributed articles of each theme

providers and OTT platforms, the convergence of wireless and wired network design, and legislation on smart TV (Rojszczak, 2020; Shim and Shin, 2019) to comprehend how these variables affect viewers' behaviour and preferences for digital content access. Several studies (Flayelle *et al.*, 2022; Kougioumtzidis *et al.*, 2022; Narwaria, 2018) have focused on measuring multimedia quality using machine learning. Smart TV platforms are anticipated to be a new medium offering interactive applications and internet-based multimedia content alongside traditional broadcast materials (Yu *et al.*, 2016).

The development of personalized recommendation algorithms and AI-driven content discovery mechanisms has transformed user engagement. OTT providers continually invest in cutting-edge technologies to ensure low latency, high-quality video delivery, and a user-centric viewing environment, illustrating the dynamic landscape of OTT infrastructure and technology (Shin and Shim, 2017).

Cluster 2: OTT consumption behaviour

OTT services are provided via the internet to deliver free phone calls, messages, applications, and media-related content and to circumvent traditional telecom networks (Chen, 2019a). Recently, the exponential growth of communication networks and the mobile internet has transcended digital media consumption (Palomba, 2022). Viewers' values are not produced by a single component but rather by the culmination of various components. Because of this, businesses are reworking their approaches to build a product that can provide "individualized and collaborative experiences" (Amoroso *et al.*, 2021). The landscape of OTT consumption behaviour is evolving rapidly, with viewers embracing personalized and on-demand content (Shin and Park, 2021). Users exhibit a discerning taste, favouring diverse genres and platforms and reflecting a shift from traditional television. The growth of OTT services has transformed the market, enabling the prediction of "what-to-watch." This shift is driven by the increasing popularity of binge-watching and the willingness of consumers to pay for premium content, as evidenced by the prevalence of multiple subscriptions (Gupta and Singharia, 2021).As viewers increasingly prioritize convenience, mobile devices have become pivotal in shaping OTT habits (Kwon *et al.*, 2021).The intersection of technology and content preferences paints a dynamic picture of OTT service consumption, emphasizing the need for content providers to adapt and innovate in response to ever-changing viewer expectations (Kwak *et al.*, 2021).

Cluster 3: Transitioning toward the OTT platform

In the contemporary media landscape, the paradigm shift towards OTT platforms signifies a revolutionary transformation in content consumption (Shin and Park, 2021). This transition is propelled by the burgeoning demand for on-demand personalized entertainment (Shin and Park, 2021). The current television paradigm is changing with traditional leaders relinquishing their dominant positions. In addition, OTT platforms, such as Netflix, HBO, Amazon Prime, and more recently, Disney + Hotstar, compete with one another to dominate the subscription market (Sanchez *et al.*, 2021). OTT platforms like Netflix and Hulu offer a wide variety of content, allowing viewers to bypass set viewing schedules. These platforms offer seamless accessibility across devices, resulting in a borderless entertainment experience (Chen, 2019b). With the proliferation of the high-speed internet, these platforms capitalize on their ability to deliver engaging content anytime and anywhere (Puthiyakath and Goswami, 2021). The changing landscape of media consumption poses significant challenges to traditional cable and satellite television. The rise of OTT platforms signifies a substantial shift in how audiences interact with media, prioritizing content and convenience over other factors.

Cluster 4: Viewers engagement in modern media

As viewers spend more time on online platforms, the internet has become an indispensable aspect of their lives. The "content is king" accurately describes what users consume online (Nagaraj *et al.*, 2021).Modern media engages viewers in a dynamic interplay between individuals and diverse content platforms, which evolves beyond traditional one-way communication and fosters reciprocal connections with digital media (Palomba, 2022).Social media, streaming services, and interactive websites foster engagement through personalized experiences, resulting in chords (Fuduric *et al.*, 2018).Users contribute, share, and curate the content to form virtual communities. Brands leverage this phenomenon by employing strategies, such as gamification and immersive storytelling, to captivate audiences (Yu *et al.*, 2016). The shift from passive observation to active participation has redefined marketing paradigms, emphasizing dialogue over monologues. This symbiotic relationship cultivates brand loyalty, as consumers seek authentic connections and meaningful interactions (Jang *et al.*, 2021). In the contemporary media landscape, viewers' engagement is an evolving narrative in which empowerment, creativity, and community intertwine (Meng and Leung, 2021).

Cluster 5: OTT in the global market

OTT platforms have transformed the global entertainment industry, gaining immense popularity in today's digital age. The media and telecommunications sectors worldwide have raised concerns about the increasing trend of cord-cutting due to digitalization in the media sector (Fuduric *et al.*, 2018). The OTT delivers audio, video, and other media content directly over the internet, bypassing traditional distribution channels. The global OTT market has witnessed exponential growth fuelled by factors such as increased internet penetration, mobile device proliferation, and a shift in viewers' preferences toward on-demand content (Park, 2019). Streaming global giants such as Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, and Disney + Hotstar dominate the market, offering diverse and exclusive content libraries. Netflix shocked the industry in 2016 with "the birth of a global Internet TV network," by announcing a simultaneous launch in 130 additional new locations, including Japan and Korea (Kim *et al.*, 2017). The growth of the industry is driven by technological advancements such as high-speed internet and advanced video compression. OTT platforms are revolutionizing how audiences consume media, leading to sustained growth and a competitive digital entertainment market (Park, 2019).

Cluster 6: OTT Policies and Regulatory Mechanisms

Regulatory frameworks are designed to promote fair competition between OTT service providers, traditional broadcasters, telecom operators, and content creators. They also aim to protect consumer rights and create a competitive environment. These frameworks enforce transparency in content recommendation algorithms, fair competition practices, and establish clear guidelines for data protection and privacy (Ramasoota and Kitikamdhorn, 2021). Advancements in technology improve content delivery and user experience on various platforms. AI and machine learning also bring new challenges for regulatory oversight, so regulatory frameworks need to include transparency requirements for AI systems to ensure accountability (Akter *et al.*, 2022) and fostering greater user empowerment and control over personalized content experiences.

Future regulatory frameworks may need to address concerns regarding algorithmic bias and discriminatory practices. The future of OTT policies and regulatory mechanisms will be shaped by a confluence of technological, economic, social, and geopolitical factors (Iordache, 2022). To navigate this complex landscape, policymakers and regulators must adopt agile, evidence-based approaches that balance innovation with accountability, protect consumer rights, and uphold democratic values in the digital age (Kim, 2022; Kostovska *et al.*, 2020).

5. Research trends and gaps

As mentioned above, this study identified six thematic clusters (see Table 4), which laid the foundation for future research. First, Cloud-based technology makes it easier for content to be delivered seamlessly across multiple platforms, ensuring a smooth viewing experience for users. ML and AI were employed to forecast viewer preferences (Akter *et al.*, 2022). These evolving technologies are essential for staying competitive within the ever-evolving landscape of streaming services. Second, the future of content delivery networks is evolving rapidly with innovations that are revolutionizing the way media is distributed, enabling customized content recommendations to suit user preferences. The third cluster focuses on capturing and retaining viewers through a better user experience and interface. Fourth, gamification and immersive storytelling can amplify viewer engagement to a greater extent. Fifth, digitalization and cross-border content distribution not only open up new opportunities for content creators but also allow viewers to experience a truly global perspective. Sixth, the regulatory mechanism ensures safeguarding users' data privacy and security, along with promoting competition among the OTT providers.

6. Theoretical implications

This study examined the OTT research landscape using a comprehensive hybrid review consisting of bibliometric and thematic analyses. This study included 101 articles extracted from the Web of Science database during the last 12 years. The theoretical implications of this study are as follows. First, our review discusses the emergence of OTT in the last decade, but it remains highly fragmented because of inconsistencies related to the methodologies and theories used in the domain of OTT research. This hybrid review focuses on past studies to understand recent developments in the domain of OTT research. Second, this study discusses different theories used by different scholars to explain the reasons for OTT adoption, usage, and consumption. TAM, UGT, and Diffusion of innovation are theories used by researchers. The theoretical framework of OTT literature is advanced by these pillars. Further, based on our review, we suggest the application of the SOBC framework and other theories, such as the media effects theory, digital divide, and dependency theory, for further studies on the dark side of OTT. These theories must be used more rigorously to advance the theoretical foundation of the OTT literature.

In future research, the TCCM framework may be employed to gain a comprehensive understanding of theories, contexts, characteristics, and methods that facilitate valuable guidance (Paul and Rosado-Serrano, 2019; Jebarajakirthy *et al.*, 2021) for future research in the area of OTT consumption and advance future research directions. It will also help researchers systematically plan, conduct, and evaluate their studies, ensuring rigour and coherence.

Furthermore, a bibliometric analysis was carried out to present a consolidated representation of these themes under six major clusters of OTT literature. This was performed to identify the different clusters in the OTT literature, which offers a thorough understanding of the various dimensions of OTT. Themes emerged from bibliographic coupling using VOS-viewer analysis. The novelty of the current research work lies mainly in classifying the clusters related to the OTT literature; hence, the framework provides a clear picture of how these elements influence viewers' adoption, usage, and consumption, based on which future research directions are also provided.

7. Practical implications

In addition to the abovementioned theoretical implications, the findings of this study will be useful for various stakeholders, including marketers, consumers, and policymakers,

S.No	Cluster/Theme	Research trends	Research questions
1	OTT Infrastructure and Technology advancement	• Innovations in content delivery networks • Cloud-based technology for media content delivery • Machine learning and AI to predict the viewer's preference for content viewing	• How technology can be used to provide a seamless viewing experience to OTT viewers? • How AI-based algorithms can be used to predict the viewer's expectations from media consumption? • How OTT eco-system can be advanced to ensure high-quality media content delivery to the viewers?
2	OTT Consumption Behavior	• Growth of communication network and changes in OTT consumption behaviour • Preference towards customized content consumption • Rise in binge-watching and its impact on viewers' behaviour	• Does customized content consumption behaviour impact the societal connection? • How does binge-watch impact the behaviour (positive or negative) of the viewers? • Which psychological factors influence the behavioural shift of OTT viewers? • What is the impact of OTT content on the changing behaviour across the different generational cohorts?
3	Shifting trends towards OTT platform	• Convenience viewing and enhancing user experience (UX) and user interface (UI) • Affordable internet and rise in OTT platforms • OTT platforms and their subscription models to attract viewers	• How rise in affordable internet services impact OTT services? • How convenience viewing is shifting the viewers' media and entertainment choices? • How traditional TV and bundling of OTT platforms has changed the viewer's perception towards entertainment services?
4	Viewers engagement in digital media	• OTT streaming services and their impact on viewers' engagement • Enhancing viewer's engagement with Gamification and immersive storytelling	• How digital media and OTT platforms are impacting the viewers' engagement? • How OTT platforms community impact consumer engagement and behaviour?
5	OTT in the global market	• Digitalisation and cross-border content distribution • Preference towards global vs local OTT content	• What are the factors responsible for the rise in the global media market? • How global internet TV network fuelled the OTT market?
6	OTT Policies and Regulatory Mechanisms	• Regulation and governance of OTT platforms for safeguarding user rights • Transparency and accountability in content recommendation algorithms	• How can regulatory mechanisms ensure data privacy and security for OTT platforms? • How regulators address the concern towards ethical practices and transparency in the OTT platforms ecosystem?

Source(s): Authors' compilation

Table 4.
Research trends and questions

associated with the entertainment and media industries, to plan and strategize their offerings to penetrate OTT viewers.

In a competitive scenario, marketers must examine the technological advancement and cultural aspects of the OTT market and understand the different patterns of viewer adoption and engagement in cross-border content. For instance, Netflix has contributed as a local and global player in cross-cultural production in the streaming era (Kim, 2022). Marketers may refer to the findings of this study as a baseline for understanding OTT consumption behaviour. Because OTT platforms are available globally, it will be beneficial for both viewers and OTT service providers (Wayne and Castro, 2021) to understand streaming market patterns, such as age-appropriate content classification, content removal, and guidelines for digital media ethics. This study offers some insightful implications for marketers targeting a more precise audience with programmatic/tailored communication. Aggregators can establish deeper connections with OTT platforms, so that their brands can reach specific geographic/demographics.

Consumers/viewers can explore a variety of personalized and high-quality content that leads to satisfaction and contentment, which increases OTT consumption. A greater variety of cross-cultural audio-visual content is now available to viewers, which has created more choices and convenience for consumption (Iordache, 2022). Viewers gain exposure to new perspectives and break down cultural barriers. OTT accommodates various languages, traditions, and storytelling styles, enabling or developing cross-cultural immersion for consumers (Kim *et al.*, 2016; Dwyer *et al.*, 2018; Chen, 2019a; Jang *et al.*, 2021).

OTT platforms facilitate the exchange of cultural narratives and foster a richer and more interconnected global society. Policymakers must ensure data privacy and security for OTT platforms as well as the role of ethical practices and transparency in the OTT platform ecosystem. The role of responsible and ethical AI (Ashok *et al.*, 2022) must be implemented to prevent discriminatory practices against viewers. Policymakers must create standards for content that can be distributed on OTT platforms such as regulations on obscenity, hate speech, violence, and harmful content.

8. Conclusion, limitation, and future research direction

In conclusion, the purpose of this hybrid review is to synthesize academic research on OTT platforms and suggest future research directions in this domain. Accordingly, the extensive literature on this domain was first compiled and examined in terms of the theoretical perspectives and methodologies used in OTT research. Subsequently, the hybrid review technique was combined with bibliographic coupling analysis, which highlighted the major OTT themes and suggested enlightening paths for OTT research advancement.

It is important to recognize the limitations of this hybrid review. First, the selected research on OTT was based on the predetermined inclusion and exclusion criteria. Second, only English-language publications were included in the analysis. As a result, it is possible that research pertinent to this field, but published in other languages, has been overlooked. The results of this hybrid review may have narrowed down the findings because of these constraints.

In the future, researchers could explore other dimensions of OTTs, including diverse geographic and demographic backgrounds, compression technology (Rojszczak, 2020), personalized and customized content (Wayne and Castro, 2021), and the use of artificial intelligence and machine learning to identify user behavioural patterns (Neira *et al.*, 2021).In addition, longitudinal, mixed-methods, and empirical studies are required for cross-border content (Chalaby, 2016), cross-cultural content (Dogruel, 2018), gamification, and immersive storytelling (Hutchins *et al.*, 2019).In the future, retaining viewers will be a challenge for OTT platforms and will offer intelligent search, enrich the user experience (UX), and user interface

(UI).Future research should focus on content investment and technological advancement in the OTT domain, the creation of original content delivery (Dwyer *et al.*, 2018), watch time, device penetration (Kim *et al.*, 2016), and seasonal subscriptions. Future studies should be conducted on the negative side of OTT platforms to measure their side effects. Managing diverse regulations and policies across various national and international boundaries is one of the biggest challenges facing the global OTT platform. Further research is needed on these issues. Researchers should explore cloud-based technologies, customer loyalty, customer profiling, and renewals in OTT platforms. Blockchain-based technology plays a vital role in curbing privacy and requires investigation (Chen *et al.*, 2018). OTT platforms are planning to produce content for various languages, so developing a model for the impact of these languages is a scope for future research.

Notes

1. Search string: OTT OR over the top OR platforms OR streaming AND services

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